Pre-Engagement Assessment

Updated March 23, 2026 | Strengthened with stakeholder interview findings

Executive Summary

Horicon Bank has strong foundational elements in place: a clear strategic vision, defined themes, emerging governance structures, and a solid tech stack. The team is thinking about the right things.

The gap is in execution readiness. Current work relies heavily on segmentation tool outputs rather than synthesized, actionable personas.

The path forward is consolidation and connection — fewer personas, tied to journeys, framed around customer aspirations.

Seven stakeholder interviews have now been completed, confirming and expanding the initial assessment. Key validation: persona work remains in infancy with frontline teams, "Together. Doing Good." has universal

stakeholder support, and youth banking emerged as a priority not in the original scope.

The kickoff conversation with Rose confirmed the persona work is still in infancy and not yet used by frontline teams. It also surfaced three immediate opportunities: the senior market in southeast Wisconsin (minimal competition), the Bank at Work program (deposit conversion from existing business loan customers), and a refined nonprofit strategy separate from the church approach.

This Validation Sprint will confirm what's working, identify what needs to change, and provide a clear roadmap for the work ahead.

Current Context

Team Situation

Marketing manager Grace recently left. Rose (SVP) is now directly overseeing the marketing team alongside trust department and business development officers. The team has capacity and ambition but needs strategic direction.

Market Challenge

Milwaukee and southeast Wisconsin remain difficult to crack. New branches (New Berlin, Tosa, Cornerstone merger locations) haven't delivered the growth expected. "If you build it, they will come" hasn't worked — the bank needs a more deliberate go-to-market approach.

Deposit Priority

Like most community banks, deposits are the primary growth lever. Several programs are in motion, but they need prioritization and clearer targeting.

Marketing Budget Reality

The ~$1.5-1.6M annual allocation includes sponsorships, credit card stock, and miscellaneous items. Approximately 70% goes to events. BrandThnk assessment: Horicon has a marketing allocation, not a marketing budget. Restructuring around persona-driven campaigns would increase impact without increasing spend.

Strengths: What You Have

Strategic Foundation

Vision

"Persona-led growth engine" — this is the right direction. Marketing is positioned as a driver of deposit growth and customer acquisition, not just a communications function.

Strategic Themes

Well-defined and aligned to business priorities:

- Customer Experience
- Community Engagement
- Competitive Differentiation
- Technology Integration
- Market Expansion & Penetration

130th Anniversary

Smart positioning. Using longevity as a narrative thread (not just a campaign) reinforces trust in emerging markets like Milwaukee and Fox Valley.

"Together. Doing Good."

Confirmed as the stronger direction. "The Natural Choice" is tied to Horicon Marsh — it doesn't resonate in Milwaukee where customers don't know the city or the marsh. "Together. Doing Good." connects to community involvement, the 130th anniversary, and the culture (40 hours paid volunteer time for all employees).

Operating Infrastructure

Governance

Monthly standups and quarterly reviews are planned. Cross-functional ownership is defined.

Tech Stack

Total Expert, Alkami (Segmint, Array), AnalyzerIQ, Vertical IQ. You're not flying blind on data — the question is how to use it.

Campaign Planning

Specific campaigns mapped with KPIs. Q1-Q4 calendar exists (though "very fluid"). Programs are categorized (Primacy & Loyalty, Community Growth,

Niche GTM, Persona Lifecycle).

Proven Programs

Senior Program

Huge existing base with strong results. Trust seminars averaging 100 attendees, generating new business. Estate planning partnerships with local attorneys. Funeral trust partnerships in development. Research shows minimal competition for senior programs in southeast Wisconsin — this is a clear opportunity.

Nonprofit Checking

Unique product that pays interest on checking balances. Recent nonprofit brought ~$1M in new deposits. Board members of nonprofits often high net worth individuals with additional banking needs.

Employee Benefit

40 hours paid volunteer time for all employees — a differentiator that connects to "Together. Doing Good." and creates organic community presence.

Youth Banking (My Money)

New youth checking product with automatic transition at age 18, debit card limit auto-increases, and plans for themed digital banking app with financial literacy. Greenlight currently pulling interchange revenue from Horicon accounts.

Gaps: What's Missing

Gap Category	Current State	What's Missing
1. Segments ≠ Personas	Describes *who customers are demographically* (life stage, NAICS code, income band)	What are they trying to accomplish? What's the narrative arc of their financial life? How does Horicon fit into their story — not just their wallet?
2. Aspiration Before Demographics	Current personas lead with who customers *are*	Mature personas lead with what customers *want to become*. "Aspirations First" approach: goals before problems, future state before current state
3. Journey Connection	Journeys mentioned in tech stack but no explicit journey mapping	Each persona connected to specific moments that matter — decision points where Horicon can show up differently than competitors
4. Operating Model	Marketing hierarchy: Themes → Programs → Campaigns	Full operating model: Frontline (what do they say/do), Midline (what systems support them), Backline (what decisions guide it all)
5. Commercial Persona Missing	Business sectors defined by NAICS codes	Operations VP confirmed: "We're a pretty big commercial bank. Shouldn't there be some focus on those business owners?" Current data

Gap Category	Current State	What's Missing
		sources don't cover small business demographics.

Confirmed in kickoff: Rose acknowledged the persona work is "in infancy" and frontline teams are not using it today. The segments came from a strategic planning session in late 2025, driven by data analytics. They're a starting point, not a destination.

Immediate Opportunities

Four opportunities that could generate near-term lift, validated through stakeholder interviews:

1. Senior Market in Southeast Wisconsin

- Minimal competition for senior programs in the Milwaukee area
- Trust seminars already averaging 100 attendees with conversion to new business
- Estate planning and funeral trust partnerships expanding reach
- Clear connection to Wealthy Achievers and Upscale Empty Nesters segments

Recommendation: Double down. This is a proven program with room to scale into underserved geography.

2. Bank at Work (Deposit Conversion)

- Business loan customers without deposit relationships represent a quick win
- Program includes employee benefits (up to $500 for checking, $300 off mortgage closing)
- Treasury management fee waivers for first 6 months
- Dedicated BDO in Milwaukee focused on this

Recommendation: Prioritize. Rose requested the customer list — this should be a 90-day priority with clear metrics.

3. Nonprofit Strategy (Separate from Churches)

- Nonprofit checking pays interest — unique offering
- Recent nonprofit brought ~$1M in new deposits
- Board members = high net worth individuals with additional banking needs
- Church symposium ROI is questionable; nonprofit strategy is cleaner

Recommendation: Separate nonprofits from churches as distinct strategies. Lead with nonprofits where the value proposition is clear and ROI is proven.

4. Youth Banking (First-Generation Builders)

- 52% of Gen Z choose banks based on values alignment
- My Money product already built with frictionless age-18 transition
- Greenlight and fintech cards pulling early-stage relationships
- "Together. Doing Good." aligns with Gen Z values-driven decisions

Recommendation: Validate as 90-day sprint candidate. Two stakeholders independently named this as their top priority.

Validation Sprint Focus

Based on this assessment and kickoff conversation, the engagement will focus on:

Area	What We'll Do
Strategy Review	Validate current direction and persona approach
Recommendations Brief	Keep, change, add — with rationale
90-Day Priorities	Identify highest-impact next steps with clear owners
Messaging Spine	Draft core messages to guide near-term execution

Stakeholder Interviews

Scheduled 30-minute conversations to gather additional perspective:

Name	Role	Lens
Brenda Heteberg	Regional Manager, Southern Region	Frontline / Contrarian
Cassie Voight	Operations, Senior Management	Backline / Strategy
Chrissy	Data Analytics	CRM / Total Expert
Natalie Colleen	Marketing	Digital / Stepped up since Grace left

Rose will send intro email; Allison will schedule directly.

Interview-Validated Themes

Execution Gap

Strategy and tech stack strong, frontline activation limited. Personas known to senior management only.

Dual-Market Challenge

Established markets (Dodge County) vs. expansion markets (Milwaukee) require different playbooks.

Simplification Imperative

Cassie Voight: "Keep it simple, stupid. We have to just simplify things." Too many priorities, too many names, too many squirrels.

Values-Based Differentiation

"Together. Doing Good." works across all markets and demographics. Even Gen Z banking decisions are values-driven.

Initial Observations: Keep, Change, Explore

Keep

"Together. Doing Good." — confirmed as the stronger direction

130th Anniversary as narrative thread

Tech stack investments (Total Expert, AnalyzerIQ, Vertical IQ)

Governance structure (monthly/quarterly cadence)

Senior program — proven, scalable

Nonprofit checking — unique, high-value

40 hours paid volunteer time — cultural differentiator

My Money youth checking product

Total Expert journey performance (0% failure rate on Gliders, 56% e-statement conversion)

Change

Retire "The Natural Choice" or limit to legacy markets where marsh resonance exists

Separate nonprofit and church strategies — different value propositions, different buyers

Consolidate ~13 segments to 3-4 actionable personas

Get persona work into frontline hands — currently marketing-only

Restructure marketing allocation into persona-driven budget with 30% cap on brand maintenance

Build post-event nurture sequences (currently missing)

Explore (This Sprint)
Bank at Work as 90-day deposit priority
Senior market expansion in southeast Wisconsin
Aspiration-first framing for core personas
Operating model beyond marketing (Frontline/Midline/Backline)
Youth banking as 90-day sprint persona
Themed digital banking app for financial literacy

What Success Looks Like

At the end of this engagement, Horicon will have:

1. **Validation:** Confirmation of what's working and what needs to change
2. **Direction:** A messaging spine that works for marketing and frontline
3. **Priorities:** A 90-day action plan with clear owners
4. **Clarity:** A roadmap for the persona and journey work ahead

The goal isn't more documentation. It's confidence in the path forward.

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